6.5 How technological developments and other factors change the media

LEARNING INTENTIONS

By the end of this chapter section, you will have learnt about:

- the influence of technological development, audiences, the individual, media industries and institutions.

The influence of technological development

Personalised algorithms drive new media technologies. Social media companies track your behaviour in order to predict the next one. They suggest content to you that your own data suggests that you would like. They don't always get it right, but you will have noticed how often Google correctly predicts what you're looking for.

Personalised algorithms fill our social media feeds with the very things that feed our basic needs of engagement, with one simple goal – to keep us online as much as possible. When Facebook introduced the 'News Feed' in 2006, owner Mark Zuckerberg was quoted as saying 'a squirrel dying in front of your house may be more relevant to your interests right now than people dying in Africa'.

Zuckerberg's words were telling. Personalised algorithms have upended the significance of news media in our lives, whose role it was to tell us what mattered and what we needed to think about. Today, our social media feeds can reinforce what we already believe and are interested in and filter out topics which it predicts we don't.



FIGURE 6.38 Mark Zuckerberg: 'a squirrel dying in front of your house may be more relevant to your interests right now than people dying in Africa'.



FIGURE 6.39 Eli Pariser, who coined the term 'filter bubbles'

FILTER BUBBLES

Writer Eli Pariser discussed the theory of **filter bubbles** in his 2011 book *Filter Bubbles: What the internet is hiding from you*. In the early years of Web 2.0, Pariser noticed the power of 'filter bubbles' to influence audience behaviour. If we only ever surrounded ourselves with ideas, content and discussion that we agreed with, we were less and less likely to encounter ideas that might challenge them. The role of traditional news media was to do just that: to give us the news of the day, regardless of how uncomfortable it may make us feel. Balanced news reporting was and is the lifeblood of a successful society as it ensures that media audiences are able to make informed decisions. Now, to some degree, we only see what we want to see. This has had a negative influence on audiences.

filter bubbles a situation in which an internet user encounters only information and opinions that conform with and reinforce their own beliefs, caused by algorithms that personalise an individual's online experience

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POLARISATION AND OUTRAGE

In 2021, an insider at Facebook released a series of documents that revealed Facebook has long known that content that makes people angry keeps them online longer. Despite the claims of Facebook that its intention is to foster closer and positive connections between its users, it does quite the opposite. The 'Facebook Papers' revealed what many media analysts had long suspected. Facebook trades on outrage. If users are angry, they are more likely to comment on a post or article and stay online.

outrage algorithms algorithms that promote content that inspire anger

Social media platforms exert considerable influence over users using '**outrage algorithms**' that come from having extensive data on users. This leads to the use of behavioural-influencing science, including:

- when we're vulnerable to influence by identifying our mood through our online behaviour
- identifying subconscious cues such as a hovering cursor that shows interest level
- employing 'dark patterns' that are designed to guide our choices by hiding content from users.[16]

CASE STUDY 6.20

Influence of audiences and individuals: TikTok

TikTok has risen in the past few years to be one of the most dominant social media platforms. Unlike other social media apps like Instagram, Snapchat and Facebook that have *some* transparency around how their algorithms work, TikTok is significantly more opaque, the algorithms being a closely guarded secret of its parent company, Bytedance. Few truly understand the reason that it has risen to be one of the most addictive social media platforms yet.

TikTok is an app for making and viewing short videos. Users scroll through the portrait-size videos as hashtags work to group users around responses to videos, 'challenges', jokes or repeating formats, or any other weird new trend emerging on the platform. At the beginning of the global pandemic in 2020, TikTok was in its infancy. However, with billions around the world stuck at home, it exploded in popularity as a means for people to connect.

What also makes TikTok different to the social media that came before it is the 'For You' feed. Unlike Instagram or Snapchat, where users nominate *who* they want to follow, TikTok does this for you, based on your behaviour. The more a user watches, the more it learns.

It is interesting then, how individuals and groups have banded together to have influence through the app. As you have already learnt, individuals can become huge stars overnight and influence trends across the platform. K-Pop fans can congregate and share similar content to engage in charity, social activism and toxic fandom.

Analysis

1. How does TikTok's algorithm differ from other social media platforms like Instagram and Snapchat, and what makes it unique in terms of content curation?
2. Explain how TikTok's popularity surged during the global pandemic in 2020 and why it became a preferred platform for people to connect.
3. How does the 'For You' feed on TikTok contribute to its addictive nature, and how does it adapt its content based on user behaviour?
4. Provide examples of how individuals and groups have utilised TikTok to gain influence and engage in various activities, such as charity, social activism and toxic fandom.

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